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POLICE INTELLIGENCE

A GRIEVOUS DISCOVERY IN THE SUBURBS

From our own Reporter

The Metropolitan Police have confirmed the discovery, in one of the suburban districts, of the body of Francine Preston, commonly known amongst her acquaintances as Dolly, who had lately been reported missing after leaving her employment at a florist's establishment.

The circumstances are described, even by persons accustomed to unpleasant duties, as of a most distressing character. Detectives at the scene are understood to have required more than one conveyance for the remains, though Commissioner Wessex, when questioned, declined to furnish particulars beyond stating that the matter remains under active investigation.

Residents of the neighbourhood speak warmly of Miss Preston, who was not a person of public station but was well regarded in the community. Renewed attention has consequently been directed toward those former outrages which certain reporters have begun, perhaps too readily, to call the Nevermore murders. Inquiry was also made concerning the possible recovery of any waxen cylinder or sound-recording article such as has been mentioned in earlier disturbances. No answer was supplied.

CITY INTELLIGENCE

FIRE AT THE UNITED ALKALI PLANT

From our City Correspondent

The men of the 13th London Fire Brigade were summoned during the night to the 300th block of South Street, where a large fire had broken out at the works of the United Alkali concern. The flames, visible for some distance, caused considerable alarm among householders and tradesmen in the adjoining streets.

Fire Chief James Maddox directed the effort, which continued for several hours before the danger was mastered. The presence of chemical materials rendered the work unusually difficult, and neighbouring premises were cleared as a precaution while the brigade endeavoured to prevent the fire from spreading beyond the plant.

Chief Maddox is reported to have observed that he had long suspected the works of presenting hazards of this description. The company has issued no extended statement, though an inquiry into the origin of the fire is expected. No general conflagration followed, a result for which the district has reason to be grateful.

PARLIAMENTARY INTELLIGENCE

QUESTIONS RESPECTING MECHANICAL CONSTABLES

From our Parliamentary Reporter

The safety of the mechanical constables, or bobby automata as they are familiarly called in some quarters, has again been questioned in the House of Lords. Lord Grimsby, speaking with considerable feeling, asked how any Englishman might trust a mechanical man without a soul.

The remark was received with a mixture of approval, amusement, and unease. Supporters of the apparatus maintain that the machines are instruments only, subject to proper direction by responsible officers. Their critics reply that an instrument moving through public streets in the semblance of authority is not so easily distinguished from the authority itself.

No immediate alteration of policy has been announced. It is understood, however, that recent disorders and accidents involving unusual electrical or mechanical circumstances have strengthened the desire of several peers for clearer public assurances.

FOREIGN INTELLIGENCE

WATCHFULNESS IN EUROPEAN CAPITALS

From our Foreign Correspondent
Berlin, July 6

Reports from Berlin, Vienna, and St. Petersburg continue to speak of official watchfulness respecting political clubs, railway stations, telegraph offices, and the movement of suspected persons. The death of the late Russian Emperor remains a powerful influence upon continental administration.

Commercial intercourse proceeds, but travellers describe an atmosphere in which police registration and the scrutiny of correspondence have become familiar features of public life. It is remarked that modern invention, while shortening distance, has not shortened suspicion.

COURT AND SOCIETY

THE SEASON AND ITS CHARITIES

From our Society Correspondent

The season continues with its accustomed procession of dinners, musicales, garden parties, and committees of charitable purpose. Hospitals serving the eastern districts have lately received particular notice, owing to the combined pressure of summer illness, industrial accident, and the several melancholy occurrences reported elsewhere in these columns.

Scientific entertainments remain fashionable, though some hostesses are said to prefer demonstrations of modest scale after recent electrical mishaps. Conversation turns readily from progress to prudence, and from prudence to the question of whether London has learned the difference.

COMMERCIAL REPORT

CHEMICAL WORKS, INSURANCE, AND APPARATUS SHARES

From our City Correspondent

Insurance houses are expected to examine closely those policies touching chemical works following the fire at the United Alkali plant. Underwriters have for some time expressed concern respecting insufficient separation of volatile materials, imperfect night watch arrangements, and the difficulty of bringing engines rapidly through crowded industrial streets.

Shares in concerns associated with municipal apparatus and signalling remain steady, though discussion in Parliament has produced some caution. Investors appear divided between confidence in mechanical order and apprehension that public sentiment may become less favourable should further accidents be laid, fairly or otherwise, at the feet of automation.

GENERAL NOTICES

RAILWAY NOTICE

Passengers using late suburban services are advised that minor alterations shall continue this week owing to permanent-way inspection and repairs to signalling apparatus.

LECTURE

At the Athenaeum Rooms, Thursday next: "Industrial Chemistry and the Duties of Public Safety." Admission by subscription; doors at half-past seven.

LOST PROPERTY

A leather physician's case, dark brown, containing several instruments and a folded memorandum, was mislaid between Holborn and Bloomsbury. The finder is requested to communicate with the Chronicle office.